THE TRAGEDY OF HAMLET, PRINCE OF DENMARK

by William Shakespeare

with the marginalia of
JOHN MILTON
JOHN KEATS

JM · John Milton **JK** · John Keats

2 readers, two centuries apart, each left a mark on this play. This edition reads The Tragedy of Hamlet, Prince of Denmark once, straight through, with every hand visible at the lines that held them — each tagged so you always know whose.

JM — John Milton owned a First Folio identified in 2019 as his own, on the evidence of its handwriting. In Hamlet he did more than mark: he corrected the Folio's text, again and again writing in the margin the word that modern editions print. His corrections and brackets are reproduced here, located directly from the Free Library of Philadelphia's own digitization.

JK — John Keats read Hamlet in his own pocket Shakespeare, seven small volumes he owned from 1817, and ran his pen under the lines he loved. Caroline Spurgeon found the play "a good deal underlined" in 1928. The copy is now at Harvard's Houghton Library; the underlinings here were read from its digitization.

Play text: the Moby Shakespeare (shakespeare.mit.edu), placed in the public domain.

John Milton: Free Library of Philadelphia's digitization of its 1623 First Folio, archive.org/details/shk00001; identification by Claire M. L. Bourne & Jason Scott-Warren (2019). No image is reproduced.

John Keats: Keats's copy of The Dramatic Works of William Shakspeare (London, 1814-18), vol. 7, Houghton Library, Harvard, *EC8 K2262 Zz814s, digitized at nrs.harvard.edu/URN-3:FHCL.HOUGH:3425902; Caroline F. E. Spurgeon, Keats's Shakespeare (1928), pp. 27-28. No image is reproduced.

A reading edition, not a scholarly one: the marks here are a first pass, not a complete paleographic inventory. Footnote placement is approximate where a reader's own edition departs in wording from the modern edited text.

ACT 1

Scene 1

[FRANCISCO at his post. Enter to him BERNARDO]
BERNARDO Who's there?
FRANCISCO Nay, answer me: stand, and unfold yourself.
BERNARDO Long live the king!
FRANCISCO Bernardo?
BERNARDO He.
FRANCISCO You come most carefully upon your hour.
BERNARDO 'Tis now struck twelve; get thee to bed,
Francisco.
FRANCISCO For this relief much thanks: 'tis bitter cold,
And I am sick at heart.
BERNARDO Have you had quiet guard?
FRANCISCO Not a mouse stirring.
BERNARDO Well, good night.
If you do meet Horatio and Marcellus,
The rivals of my watch, bid them make haste.
FRANCISCO I think I hear them. Stand, ho! Who's there?
[Enter HORATIO and MARCELLUS]
HORATIO Friends to this ground.
MARCELLUS And liegemen to the Dane.
FRANCISCO Give you good night.
MARCELLUS O, farewell, honest soldier:
Who hath relieved you?
FRANCISCO Bernardo has my place.
Give you good night.
[Exit]
MARCELLUS Holla! Bernardo!
BERNARDO Say,
What, is Horatio there?
HORATIO A piece of him.
BERNARDO Welcome, Horatio: welcome, good Marcellus.

MARCELLUS What, has this thing appear'd again to-night?
BERNARDO I have seen nothing.
MARCELLUS Horatio says 'tis but our fantasy,
And will not let belief take hold of him
Touching this dreaded sight, twice seen of us:
Therefore I have entreated him along
With us to watch the minutes of this night;
That if again this apparition come,
He may approve our eyes and speak to it.
HORATIO Tush, tush, 'twill not appear.
BERNARDO Sit down awhile;
And let us once again assail your ears,
That are so fortified against our story
What we have two nights seen.
HORATIO Well, sit we down,
And let us hear Bernardo speak of this.
BERNARDO Last night of all,
When yond same star that's westward from the pole JM JK
Had made his course to illume that part of heaven JM JK
Where now it burns, Marcellus and myself, JM JK
The bell then beating one,-- JK
[Enter Ghost]
MARCELLUS Peace, break thee off; look, where it comes again!
BERNARDO In the same figure, like the king that's dead.
MARCELLUS Thou art a scholar; speak to it, Horatio.
BERNARDO Looks it not like the king? mark it, Horatio.
HORATIO Most like: it harrows me with fear and wonder.
BERNARDO It would be spoke to.
MARCELLUS Question it, Horatio.
HORATIO What art thou that usurp'st this time of night,
Together with that fair and warlike form
In which the majesty of buried Denmark
Did sometimes march? by heaven I charge thee, speak!
MARCELLUS It is offended.
BERNARDO See, it stalks away!

JM *Bracketed in the margin: Bernardo's star, the bell beating one. Keats underlined the same lines.* (Folio p. 152)

JK *Underlined, to "The bell then beating one."* (Keats's copy, p. 4)

HORATIO Stay! speak, speak! I charge thee, speak!
[Exit Ghost]
MARCELLUS 'Tis gone, and will not answer.
BERNARDO How now, Horatio! you tremble and look
pale:
Is not this something more than fantasy?
What think you on't?
HORATIO Before my God, I might not this believe
Without the sensible and true avouch
Of mine own eyes.
MARCELLUS Is it not like the king?
HORATIO As thou art to thyself:
Such was the very armour he had on
When he the ambitious Norway combated;
So frown'd he once, when, in an angry parle,
He smote the sledded Polacks on the ice.
'Tis strange.
MARCELLUS Thus twice before, and jump at this dead
hour,
With martial stalk hath he gone by our watch.
HORATIO In what particular thought to work I know not;
But in the gross and scope of my opinion,
This bodes some strange eruption to our state.
MARCELLUS Good now, sit down, and tell me, he that
knows,
Why this same strict and most observant watch
So nightly toils the subject of the land,
And why such daily cast of brazen cannon,
And foreign mart for implements of war;
Why such impress of shipwrights, whose sore task
Does not divide the Sunday from the week;
What might be toward, that this sweaty haste
Doth make the night joint-labourer with the day:
Who is't that can inform me?
HORATIO That can I;
At least, the whisper goes so. Our last king,
Whose image even but now appear'd to us,

Was, as you know, by Fortinbras of Norway,
Thereto prick'd on by a most emulate pride,
Dared to the combat; in which our valiant Hamlet--
For so this side of our known world esteem'd him--
Did slay this Fortinbras; who by a seal'd compact,
Well ratified by law and heraldry,
Did forfeit, with his life, all those his lands
Which he stood seized of, to the conqueror:
Against the which, a moiety competent
Was gaged by our king; which had return'd
To the inheritance of Fortinbras,
Had he been vanquisher; as, by the same covenant,
And carriage of the article design'd,
His fell to Hamlet. Now, sir, young Fortinbras,
Of unimproved mettle hot and full,
Hath in the skirts of Norway here and there
Shark'd up a list of lawless resolutes,
For food and diet, to some enterprise
That hath a stomach in't; which is no other--
As it doth well appear unto our state--
But to recover of us, by strong hand
And terms compulsatory, those foresaid lands
So by his father lost: and this, I take it,
Is the main motive of our preparations,
The source of this our watch and the chief head
Of this post-haste and romage in the land.
BERNARDO I think it be no other but e'en so:
Well may it sort that this portentous figure
Comes armed through our watch; so like the king
That was and is the question of these wars.
HORATIO A mote it is to trouble the mind's eye.
In the most high and palmy state of Rome,
A little ere the mightiest Julius fell,
The graves stood tenantless and the sheeted dead
Did squeak and gibber in the Roman streets:
As stars with trains of fire and dews of blood,
Disasters in the sun; and the moist star

Upon whose influence Neptune's empire stands
Was sick almost to doomsday with eclipse:
And even the like precurse of fierce events,
As harbingers preceding still the fates
And prologue to the omen coming on,
Have heaven and earth together demonstrated
Unto our climatures and countrymen.--
But soft, behold! lo, where it comes again!
[Re-enter Ghost]
I'll cross it, though it blast me. Stay, illusion!
If thou hast any sound, or use of voice,
Speak to me:
If there be any good thing to be done,
That may to thee do ease and grace to me,
Speak to me:
[Cock crows]
If thou art privy to thy country's fate,
Which, happily, foreknowing may avoid, O, speak!
Or if thou hast uphoarded in thy life
Extorted treasure in the womb of earth,
For which, they say, you spirits oft walk in death,
Speak of it: stay, and speak! Stop it, Marcellus.
MARCELLUS Shall I strike at it with my partisan?
HORATIO Do, if it will not stand.
BERNARDO 'Tis here!
HORATIO 'Tis here!
MARCELLUS 'Tis gone!
[Exit Ghost]
We do it wrong, being so majestical, JK
To offer it the show of violence; JK
For it is, as the air, invulnerable, JK
And our vain blows malicious mockery.
BERNARDO It was about to speak, when the cock crew.
HORATIO And then it started like a guilty thing
Upon a fearful summons. I have heard,

JK *Underlined.* (Keats's copy, p. 7)

The cock, that is the trumpet to the morn, JM
Doth with his lofty and shrill-sounding throat
Awake the god of day; and, at his warning,
Whether in sea or fire, in earth or air,
The extravagant and erring spirit hies
To his confine: and of the truth herein
This present object made probation.
MARCELLUS It faded on the crowing of the cock. JM
Some say that ever 'gainst that season comes JM
Wherein our Saviour's birth is celebrated, JM
The bird of dawning singeth all night long: JM JK
And then, they say, no spirit dares stir abroad; JM JK
The nights are wholesome; then no planets strike, JM JK
No fairy takes, nor witch hath power to charm, JM JK
So hallow'd and so gracious is the time. JM JK
HORATIO So have I heard and do in part believe it.
But, look, the morn, in russet mantle clad, JM JK
Walks o'er the dew of yon high eastward hill: JM JK
Break we our watch up; and by my advice,
Let us impart what we have seen to-night
Unto young Hamlet; for, upon my life,
This spirit, dumb to us, will speak to him.
Do you consent we shall acquaint him with it,
As needful in our loves, fitting our duty?
MARCELLUS Let's do't, I pray; and I this morning know
Where we shall find him most conveniently.
[Exeunt]

JM *The Folio printed "the trumpet to the day." Milton struck out "day" and wrote "morn" beside it, the word this text and modern editions print.* (Folio p. 153)

JM *Bracketed: the bird of dawning that sings all night at Christmas. Keats underlined it too.* (Folio p. 153)

JK *Underlined, "the exquisite line", in Spurgeon's words.*
(Keats's copy, p. 8; Spurgeon p. 28)

JM *Bracketed with the speech before it: the morn in russet mantle.* (Folio p. 153)

JK *Underlined: Horatio's sunrise, which Spurgeon singles out.*
(Keats's copy, p. 8; Spurgeon p. 28)

Scene 2

[Enter KING CLAUDIUS, QUEEN GERTRUDE, HAMLET, POLONIUS, LAERTES, VOLTIMAND, CORNELIUS, Lords, and Attendants]
KING CLAUDIUS Though yet of Hamlet our dear brother's death
The memory be green, and that it us befitted
To bear our hearts in grief and our whole kingdom

To be contracted in one brow of woe,
Yet so far hath discretion fought with nature
That we with wisest sorrow think on him,
Together with remembrance of ourselves.
Therefore our sometime sister, now our queen,
The imperial jointress to this warlike state,
Have we, as 'twere with a defeated joy,--
With an auspicious and a dropping eye,
With mirth in funeral and with dirge in marriage,
In equal scale weighing delight and dole,--
Taken to wife: nor have we herein barr'd
Your better wisdoms, which have freely gone
With this affair along. For all, our thanks.
Now follows, that you know, young Fortinbras,
Holding a weak supposal of our worth,
Or thinking by our late dear brother's death
Our state to be disjoint and out of frame,
Colleagued with the dream of his advantage,
He hath not fail'd to pester us with message,
Importing the surrender of those lands
Lost by his father, with all bonds of law,
To our most valiant brother. So much for him.
Now for ourself and for this time of meeting:
Thus much the business is: we have here writ
To Norway, uncle of young Fortinbras,--
Who, impotent and bed-rid, scarcely hears
Of this his nephew's purpose,--to suppress
His further gait herein; in that the levies,
The lists and full proportions, are all made
Out of his subject: and we here dispatch
You, good Cornelius, and you, Voltimand,
For bearers of this greeting to old Norway;
Giving to you no further personal power
To business with the king, more than the scope
Of these delated articles allow.
Farewell, and let your haste commend your duty.

VOLTIMAND In that and all things will we show our duty.
KING CLAUDIUS We doubt it nothing: heartily farewell.
[Exeunt VOLTIMAND and CORNELIUS]
And now, Laertes, what's the news with you?
You told us of some suit; what is't, Laertes?
You cannot speak of reason to the Dane,
And loose your voice: what wouldst thou beg, Laertes,
That shall not be my offer, not thy asking?
The head is not more native to the heart,
The hand more instrumental to the mouth,
Than is the throne of Denmark to thy father.
What wouldst thou have, Laertes?
LAERTES My dread lord,
Your leave and favour to return to France;
From whence though willingly I came to Denmark,
To show my duty in your coronation,
Yet now, I must confess, that duty done,
My thoughts and wishes bend again toward France
And bow them to your gracious leave and pardon.
KING CLAUDIUS Have you your father's leave? What says Polonius?
LORD POLONIUS He hath, my lord, wrung from me my slow leave
By laboursome petition, and at last
Upon his will I seal'd my hard consent:
I do beseech you, give him leave to go.
KING CLAUDIUS Take thy fair hour, Laertes; time be thine,
And thy best graces spend it at thy will!
But now, my cousin Hamlet, and my son,--
HAMLET [Aside] A little more than kin, and less than kind.
KING CLAUDIUS How is it that the clouds still hang on you?
HAMLET Not so, my lord; I am too much i' the sun.

QUEEN GERTRUDE Good Hamlet, cast thy nighted
colour off,
And let thine eye look like a friend on Denmark.
Do not for ever with thy vailed lids
Seek for thy noble father in the dust:
Thou know'st 'tis common; all that lives must die,
Passing through nature to eternity.
HAMLET Ay, madam, it is common.
QUEEN GERTRUDE If it be,
Why seems it so particular with thee?
HAMLET Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'
'Tis not alone my inky cloak, good mother,
Nor customary suits of solemn black,
Nor windy suspiration of forced breath,
No, nor the fruitful river in the eye,
Nor the dejected 'havior of the visage,
Together with all forms, moods, shapes of grief,
That can denote me truly: these indeed seem,
For they are actions that a man might play:
But I have that within which passeth show;
These but the trappings and the suits of woe.
KING CLAUDIUS 'Tis sweet and commendable in your
nature, Hamlet,
To give these mourning duties to your father:
But, you must know, your father lost a father;
That father lost, lost his, and the survivor bound
In filial obligation for some term
To do obsequious sorrow: but to persever
In obstinate condolement is a course
Of impious stubbornness; 'tis unmanly grief;
It shows a will most incorrect to heaven,
A heart unfortified, a mind impatient,
An understanding simple and unschool'd:
For what we know must be and is as common
As any the most vulgar thing to sense,
Why should we in our peevish opposition
Take it to heart? Fie! 'tis a fault to heaven,

A fault against the dead, a fault to nature,
To reason most absurd: whose common theme
Is death of fathers, and who still hath cried,
From the first corse till he that died to-day,
'This must be so.' We pray you, throw to earth
This unprevailing woe, and think of us
As of a father: for let the world take note,
You are the most immediate to our throne;
And with no less nobility of love
Than that which dearest father bears his son,
Do I impart toward you. For your intent
In going back to school in Wittenberg,
It is most retrograde to our desire:
And we beseech you, bend you to remain
Here, in the cheer and comfort of our eye,
Our chiefest courtier, cousin, and our son.
QUEEN GERTRUDE Let not thy mother lose her prayers,
Hamlet:
I pray thee, stay with us; go not to Wittenberg.
HAMLET I shall in all my best obey you, madam.
KING CLAUDIUS Why, 'tis a loving and a fair reply:
Be as ourself in Denmark. Madam, come;
This gentle and unforced accord of Hamlet
Sits smiling to my heart: in grace whereof,
No jocund health that Denmark drinks to-day,
But the great cannon to the clouds shall tell,
And the king's rouse the heavens all bruit again,
Re-speaking earthly thunder. Come away.
[Exeunt all but HAMLET]
HAMLET O, that this too too solid flesh would melt JK
Thaw and resolve itself into a dew! JK
Or that the Everlasting had not fix'd
His canon 'gainst self-slaughter! O God! God!
How weary, stale, flat and unprofitable,
Seem to me all the uses of this world!
Fie on't! ah fie! 'tis an unweeded garden,
That grows to seed; things rank and gross in nature

JK *Underlined, with a stroke down the margin beside the lines after it.*
(Keats's copy, p. 12; Spurgeon p. 28)

Possess it merely. That it should come to this!
But two months dead: nay, not so much, not two:
So excellent a king; that was, to this,
Hyperion to a satyr; so loving to my mother JM JK
That he might not beteem the winds of heaven JM JK
Visit her face too roughly. Heaven and earth! JM JK
Must I remember? why, she would hang on him, JM JK
As if increase of appetite had grown JM JK
By what it fed on: and yet, within a month-- JM
Let me not think on't--Frailty, thy name is woman!-- JM
A little month, or ere those shoes were old
With which she follow'd my poor father's body,
Like Niobe, all tears:--why she, even she--
O, God! a beast, that wants discourse of reason,
Would have mourn'd longer--married with my uncle,
My father's brother, but no more like my father
Than I to Hercules: within a month:
Ere yet the salt of most unrighteous tears
Had left the flushing in her galled eyes,
She married. O, most wicked speed, to post
With such dexterity to incestuous sheets!
It is not nor it cannot come to good:
But break, my heart; for I must hold my tongue.
[Enter HORATIO, MARCELLUS, and BERNARDO]
HORATIO Hail to your lordship!
HAMLET I am glad to see you well:
Horatio,--or I do forget myself.
HORATIO The same, my lord, and your poor servant ever.
HAMLET Sir, my good friend; I'll change that name with
you:
And what make you from Wittenberg, Horatio? Marcellus?
MARCELLUS My good lord--
HAMLET I am very glad to see you. Good even, sir.
But what, in faith, make you from Wittenberg?
HORATIO A truant disposition, good my lord.
HAMLET I would not hear your enemy say so,
Nor shall you do mine ear that violence,

JM *A long bracket down the first soliloquy, ending at "Frailty, thy name is woman."* (Folio p. 154)

JK *Underlined, line after line, through the soliloquy.* (Keats's copy, p. 12)

To make it truster of your own report
Against yourself: I know you are no truant.
But what is your affair in Elsinore?
We'll teach you to drink deep ere you depart.
HORATIO My lord, I came to see your father's funeral.
HAMLET I pray thee, do not mock me, fellow-student;
I think it was to see my mother's wedding.
HORATIO Indeed, my lord, it follow'd hard upon.
HAMLET Thrift, thrift, Horatio! the funeral baked meats JK
Did coldly furnish forth the marriage tables. JK
Would I had met my dearest foe in heaven JK
Or ever I had seen that day, Horatio! JK
My father!--methinks I see my father.
HORATIO Where, my lord?
HAMLET In my mind's eye, Horatio.
HORATIO I saw him once; he was a goodly king.
HAMLET He was a man, take him for all in all, JK
I shall not look upon his like again. JK
HORATIO My lord, I think I saw him yesternight.
HAMLET Saw? who?
HORATIO My lord, the king your father.
HAMLET The king my father!
HORATIO Season your admiration for awhile
With an attent ear, till I may deliver,
Upon the witness of these gentlemen,
This marvel to you.
HAMLET For God's love, let me hear.
HORATIO Two nights together had these gentlemen,
Marcellus and Bernardo, on their watch,
In the dead vast and middle of the night,
Been thus encounter'd. A figure like your father,
Armed at point exactly, cap-a-pe,
Appears before them, and with solemn march
Goes slow and stately by them: thrice he walk'd

JK *Underlined: the funeral baked meats.* (Keats's copy, p. 13)

JK *Underlined.* (Keats's copy, p. 13)

By their oppress'd and fear-surprised eyes, JM JK
Within his truncheon's length; whilst they, distilled JM JK
Almost to jelly with the act of fear,
Stand dumb and speak not to him. This to me
In dreadful secrecy impart they did;
And I with them the third night kept the watch;
Where, as they had deliver'd, both in time,
Form of the thing, each word made true and good,
The apparition comes: I knew your father;
These hands are not more like.
HAMLET But where was this?
MARCELLUS My lord, upon the platform where we watch'd.
HAMLET Did you not speak to it?
HORATIO My lord, I did;
But answer made it none: yet once methought
It lifted up its head and did address
Itself to motion, like as it would speak;
But even then the morning cock crew loud,
And at the sound it shrunk in haste away,
And vanish'd from our sight.
HAMLET 'Tis very strange.
HORATIO As I do live, my honour'd lord, 'tis true;
And we did think it writ down in our duty
To let you know of it.
HAMLET Indeed, indeed, sirs, but this troubles me.
Hold you the watch to-night?
BERNARDO We do, my lord.
HAMLET Arm'd, say you?
BERNARDO Arm'd, my lord.
HAMLET From top to toe?
BERNARDO My lord, from head to foot.
HAMLET Then saw you not his face?
HORATIO O, yes, my lord; he wore his beaver up.
HAMLET What, look'd he frowningly?
HORATIO A countenance more in sorrow than in anger.
HAMLET Pale or red?

JM *The Folio printed "Be their opprest." Milton crossed the "e" and wrote "by" in the margin. Keats underlined this line.* (Folio p. 155)

JK *Underlined, the line Milton corrected in his Folio.* (Keats's copy, p. 14)

JM *Where the Folio has "bestil'd", Milton marked the "be" and wrote "di" above it: distill'd, as this text reads.* (Folio p. 155)